

HOUSE BILL 1822

By Cochran

AN ACT to amend Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 49,  
relative to education.

BE IT ENACTED BY THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE:

SECTION 1. Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 49, Chapter 6, Part 10, is amended by  
adding the following as a new section:

(a) The general assembly finds and declares that:

(1) Teaching the historical, positive impact of religion on American history  
is consistent with the First Amendment to the United States Constitution;

(2) An accurate and historical account of the influence of Judeo-Christian  
values on the freedom and liberties ingrained in our culture is imperative to  
reducing ignorance of American history, hate, and violence in our society; and

(3) Accurate instruction on the verifiable, historical impacts of religion on  
American history is not proselytization or a violation of the First Amendment.

(b) When providing instruction to students on the topic of American history,  
LEAs, public charter schools, and teachers in public schools may provide instruction on  
the positive impacts of religion on American history, which may include:

(1) The history of the pilgrims, including:

(A) The organization of the Pilgrims as a church;

(B) The history of the *Embarkation of the Pilgrims*, which is a  
painting displayed in the United States capitol rotunda depicting prayer,  
an open bible, and the inscription "God with us" on the ship sail;

(C) The religious implications of the Mayflower Compact, which  
was modeled on a church covenant;

(D) The Pilgrim-Wampanoag peace treaty signed and upheld by the Pilgrims with the Wampanoag tribe; and

(E) The first Thanksgiving in 1621, which was observed as an act of gratitude toward God;

(2) The appeals to divine power and protection embedded in the Declaration of Independence;

(3) The appeal made to the biblical exodus in the fight for independence;

(4) The religious views of the signers of the Declaration of Independence;

(5) The influence of religious leaders like Reverend John Witherspoon, who signed the Declaration of Independence;

(6) The impact of the first and second great awakenings on public policy;

(7) George Washington's direction regarding chaplains in the army;

(8) George Washington's farewell address calling religion and morality indispensable supports leading to political prosperity and "great pillars of human happiness" and the "firmest props of the duties of men and citizens";

(9) Benjamin Franklin's appeal for prayer at the constitutional convention and the hiring of chaplains that followed;

(10) The influence of religion on the United States Constitution, as evidenced by the exclusion of Sunday from the allotted time for the president to sign or veto a bill and dating of the Constitution according to the birth of Christ;

(11) Reverend John Leland's influence that led James Madison to advocate for a Bill of Rights to the United States Constitution;

(12) The history of the concept of separating church and state dating back to its religious origins with Roger Williams;

(13) The influence and debates of Reverend John Peter Gabriel Muhlenberg and his brother, Frederick Augustus Conrad Muhlenberg, who was the first speaker of the United States house of representatives;

(14) The historic role of the Black Robe Regiment;

(15) The response to *The Age of Reason* by Thomas Paine, including Benjamin Franklin's suggestion that Paine burn it, the national rejection of it, and the multiple responses to it, including *The Age of Revelation* by Elias Boudinot;

(16) The role of the Ten Commandments in shaping American law and its presence in art and sculpture displayed in the United States supreme court;

(17) How religious influences shaped American civil rights and the Civil Rights Movement, as demonstrated by Booker T. Washington, Frederick Douglass, Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr., and others;

(18) The impact of religious leaders on the culture of this nation, including, but not limited to, the evangelist minister Billy Graham; and

(19) The history of the national motto "In God We Trust," beginning with the national anthem and continuing through its appearance on currency, as well as the inclusion of "under God" to this nation's pledge of allegiance.

SECTION 2. Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 49, Chapter 7, Part 1, is amended by adding the following as a new section:

When providing instruction on the topic of American history, faculty or instructors employed at a public institution of higher education may provide instruction on the positive impacts of religion on American history, which may include:

(1) The history of the Pilgrims, including:

(A) The organization of the Pilgrims as a church;

(B) The history of the *Embarkation of the Pilgrims*, which is a painting displayed in the United States capitol rotunda depicting prayer, an open bible, and the inscription "God with us" on the ship sail;

(C) The religious implications of the Mayflower Compact, which was modeled on a church covenant;

(D) The Pilgrim-Wampanoag peace treaty signed and upheld by the Pilgrims with the Wampanoag tribe; and

(E) The first Thanksgiving in 1621, which was observed as an act of gratitude toward God;

(2) The appeals to divine power and protection embedded in the Declaration of Independence;

(3) The appeal made to the biblical exodus in the fight for independence;

(4) The religious views of the signers of the Declaration of Independence;

(5) The influence of religious leaders like Reverend John Witherspoon, who signed the Declaration of Independence;

(6) The impact of the first and second great awakenings on public policy;

(7) George Washington's direction regarding chaplains in the army;

(8) George Washington's farewell address calling religion and morality indispensable supports leading to political prosperity and "great pillars of human happiness" and the "firmest props of the duties of men and citizens";

(9) Benjamin Franklin's appeal for prayer at the constitutional convention and the hiring of chaplains that followed;

(10) The influence of religion on the United States Constitution, as evidenced by the exclusion of Sunday from the allotted time for the president to sign or veto a bill and dating of the Constitution according to the birth of Christ;

(11) Reverend John Leland's influence that led James Madison to advocate for a Bill of Rights to the United States Constitution;

(12) The history of the concept of separating church and state dating back to its religious origins with Roger Williams;

(13) The influence and debates of Reverend John Peter Gabriel Muhlenberg and his brother, Frederick Augustus Conrad Muhlenberg, who was the first speaker of the United States house of representatives;

(14) The historic role of the Black Robe Regiment;

(15) The response to *The Age of Reason* by Thomas Paine, including Benjamin Franklin's suggestion that Paine burn it, the national rejection of it, and the multiple responses to it, including *The Age of Revelation* by Elias Boudinot;

(16) The role of the Ten Commandments in shaping American law and its presence in art and sculpture displayed in the United States supreme court;

(17) How religious influences shaped American civil rights and the Civil Rights Movement, as demonstrated by Booker T. Washington, Frederick Douglass, Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr., and others;

(18) The impact of religious leaders on the culture of this nation, including, but not limited to, the evangelist minister Billy Graham; and

(19) The history of the national motto "In God We Trust," beginning with the national anthem and continuing through its appearance on currency, as well as the inclusion of "under God" to this nation's pledge of allegiance.

SECTION 3. This act takes effect July 1, 2026, the public welfare requiring it, and applies to the 2026-2027 academic year and each academic year thereafter.